had seriously studied China, and they recognized it for what it was, a diplomatic bear-trap. There were sceptics inside the Indian establishment who derided such thinking as archaic or even obstructive. They felt that a bilateral agreement on border trade constituted a Chinese acknowledgement of the ground reality in Sikkim, and were confident that, in time, it would lead the Chinese to de jure recognition on Sikkim as a State of India. The solution to the Sikkim Question, therefore, tested the mettle of the Government of India in its entirety. Had the officials in the External Affairs Ministry buckled under pressure, the Chinese might have achieved their objectives rather easily. Fortunately, the attempts of the Gujral government to resolve the issue stalled with the change in government.

When the National Democratic Alliance Government of Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee took office in March 1998, the Governments of India and China almost immediately had to grapple with the fallout of India's nuclear tests on the bilateral relationship. This was followed by the Kargil conflict. Hence, in the first three years of Vajpayee's tenure, no real opportunity to resolve the Sikkim Question arose. The first opportunity that India got to raise this matter, once the two sides had put away the nuclear issue and restored normality in their relations, was in January 2002, when Chinese Premier Zhu Rongji came visiting New Delhi. His was the first visit at the level of Head of State or Government from the Chinese side since President Jiang Zemin's visit in November 1996. India was fortunate that it had, in Prime Minister Vajpayee and his National Security Advisor Brajesh Mishra, two individuals who had an excellent understanding of India–China relations. They had already initiated the exercise for clarification of the Line of Actual Control in 2000, and decided that it was the time to push the envelope on Sikkim. Vajpayee, therefore, raised the matter with